



CLEARCODE
READING

Comprehension Strategy Pack

Grades 6–8

Comprehension Strategy Pack (6–8)

What are comprehension strategies?

Strong readers construct mental maps as they read, which helps them understand the text. Strong readers know that texts in the same genre can have similar structures. These structural characteristics serve as landmarks on their mental map. For example, when reading a story, a strong reader knows that fiction texts have characters that encounter a problem. The character makes attempts to solve the problem. At the end, they usually solve the problem and learn a lesson. Because they have these landmarks already on their mental map, they are able to keep track of the most relevant details in the text and piece those details together to make meaning. This mental map metaphor extends to informational texts as well. Informational texts have a variety of structures: chronological/sequence, description, compare and contrast, cause and effect, and problem/solution. When your child understands how the author organized the information in the text, they can more easily identify the most relevant details and distill the main idea.

How do comprehension strategies work?

The comprehension strategies included in this pack are designed to help your child construct a mental map as they read. So, while you're reading with your child, make understanding the focus instead of sounding out the words or reading fluently. These skills can take up a lot of mental energy, and make comprehension harder. Your child does not have to read the text on their own in order to practice comprehension. You can read aloud to them, take turns reading, or read side-by-side. If your child is reading aloud to you and comes across a word they do not know, help them sound it out or tell it to them.

One way you can support your child in constructing a clear mental map is by making visible what strong readers notice and think about as they read. Here's how it works:

1. Pick a book your child is interested in reading.
2. Introduce one strategy at a time. Explain what the strategy is, the focus question, and the steps.
3. Take turns reading a section of the book. You can alternate reading sentences, paragraphs, or pages.
4. Pause and show them how you would use the strategy.
5. Continue reading and pausing to use the strategy until your child feels comfortable with the strategy.

What comprehension strategies are included in this pack?

Your child only needs one or two strategies for each type of text to build a clear mental map. There are two strategies for fiction texts and two for informational texts in this pack. Start with the first strategy listed.

Fiction	Informational
- Plot Pyramid - Compare FAST+Traits	5Ws+H: Who? What? When? Where? Why? How? - Text Structure + Focus Question

Plot Pyramid

Introduce the strategy: *Show your child the graphic organizer as you introduce the Plot Pyramid.*

- All stories have a similar structure. We can remember the structure by thinking about a pyramid.
 - **Exposition**, or the characters, setting, and situation at the beginning of the story
 - **Conflict**, or something that goes wrong, an argument between characters
 - **Rising Action**, or events that happen that build suspense
 - **Climax**, or a turning point in the story, usually related to the conflict
 - **Falling Action**, or the events that lead to the end of the story
 - **Resolution**, or how the story ends
 - **Theme**, or the message of the story, usually about the lesson the character learns.

Focus Question: After you read a story, ask: What happened in the story?

Steps:

1. Read part of the story.
2. Pause and ask if you learned any new details to add to your plot pyramid.
3. Jot down the answer on the graphic organizer.
4. Continue to read, pause, and ask until you finish the story. *This can occur over multiple sessions.*
5. Ask the **Theme** question: What does the author want us to learn from the character?

Compare FAST+Traits: Feelings, Actions, Sayings, Thoughts + Traits

Introduce the strategy: *Show your child the graphic organizer as you introduce the FAST+Traits strategy.*

- Authors use details to show and tell us what qualities a character has – if they are a kind or mean, trustworthy or dishonest. We can remember these important details with the acronym: FAST+Traits.
 - **Feelings**, a character's emotions about a situation or another character
 - **Actions**, a character's behaviors in a situation
 - **Sayings**, or what a character says out loud to other characters
 - **Thoughts**, or what a character thinks in their head
 - **Traits** are the qualities a character has. They are kind, dishonest, brave, cowardly, etc.

Focus Question: After you read a story, ask: How did the character change?

Steps:

1. Read part of the story.
2. Pause and ask if you learned any new FAST details.
 - **Feelings:** How does the character feel in this moment?
 - **Actions:** What did the character do?
 - **Sayings:** What did the character say?
 - **Thoughts:** What is the character thinking in this moment?
 - **Traits:** What kind of person is this character?
3. Go back and reread if you missed one of these details. Jot down the answer on the graphic organizer.
4. Continue to read, pause, and ask *over multiple sessions* until you are about halfway through the story.
5. Repeat steps 1–4 with a new FAST+Traits organizer for the second half of the story.
6. Compare your organizers. Ask the Focus Question: How did the character change?

5Ws+H: Who? What? When? Where? Why? How?

Introduce the strategy: *Show your child the graphic organizer as you introduce the 5Ws+H strategy.*

- Authors use details to show and tell us about a topic. We can identify these important details by asking W and H questions as we read. We can remember these questions as 5Ws+H.
 - **Who** is the author telling us about?
 - **What** is the author telling us about?
 - **When** did these events happen?
 - **Where** did these events happen?
 - **Why** did this happen?
 - **How** did this happen? Or **How** are these things related?

Focus Question: After you read a story, ask: What is the text about? What does the author want me to learn about this topic?

Steps:

1. Read a section of the text.
2. Pause and ask if you can answer any W or H questions. *Use the picture cards as you ask each question.*
 - **Who** is...?
 - **What** is...?
 - **When** did...?
 - **Where** did...?
 - **Why** did ...?
 - **How** did ...? Or **How** are ____ and ____ related?
3. Go back and find where the answer is in the text. Jot down the answer on the graphic organizer.
4. Continue to read, pause, and ask until you finish the text. *This can occur over multiple sessions.*
5. Explain what the text was about using the details from the text.

Text Structure + Focus Question

Introduce the strategy: *Show your child the text structure handout as you introduce the strategy.*

- Authors organize informational texts to help readers understand the main idea and key details.
 - This is called text structure. There are five different structures for informational texts.
 - If the text structure is compare and contrast, the main idea will be about the similarities and differences between two things.
 - There's a graphic organizer and a focus question frame for each text structure.
- Authors give readers a clue about the main idea in the title and subheadings of informational texts. Use the title to complete the focus question frame for the text. The key details that answer the question will help you understand the main idea.

Focus Question Frame: This is listed at the top of each graphic organizer.

Steps:

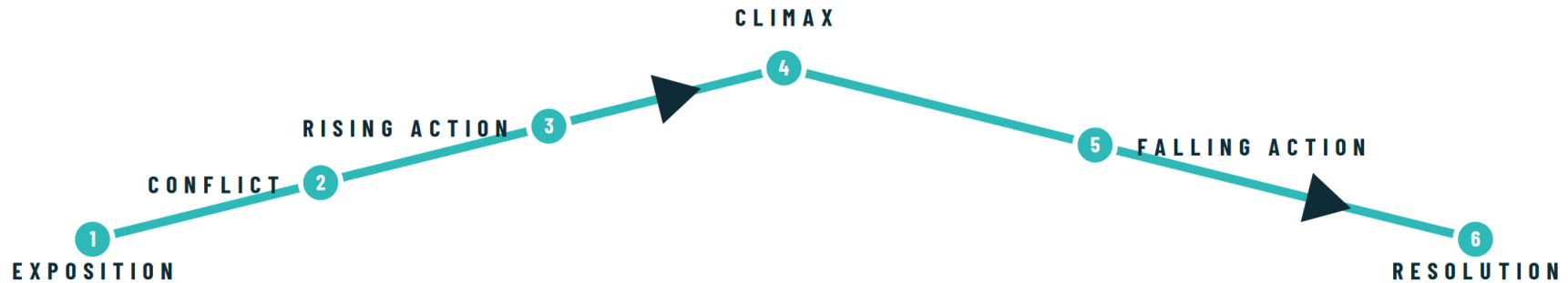
1. Preview the text to identify the text structure. Fill in the Focus Question Frame using words from the title.
2. Read a section of the text. Pause and ask if you can answer your Focus Question.
3. Write the answer to the question on your graphic organizer.
4. Continue to read, pause, and ask until you finish the text. *This can occur over multiple sessions.*
5. Explain what the text was about using the details from the text.

PLOT PYRAMID

Name _____ Date _____

FOCUS QUESTION What happened in the story?

Use the diagram to find each part of the plot. Write what happened on the matching line below.



1	EXPOSITION	the characters, setting, and situation at the beginning	_____
2	CONFLICT	something that goes wrong	_____
3	RISING ACTION	events that build suspense	_____ _____ _____
4	CLIMAX	the turning point	_____ _____
5	FALLING ACTION	events that lead to the end	_____ _____ _____
6	RESOLUTION	how the story ends	_____ _____
7	THEME	the lesson the character learns	_____

FAST + Traits

Feelings · Actions · Sayings · Thoughts + Traits

Character: _____ **Book:** _____

FOCUS QUESTION: What do these details from the text reveal about the character?

Feelings How does the character feel in this moment?	
Actions What did the character do?	
Sayings What did the character say?	
Thoughts What is the character thinking in this moment?	
Traits What kind of person is this character? What do these details reveal?	

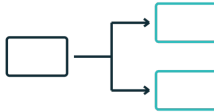
CHARACTER TRAIT WORDS *Pick the word your evidence proves.*

Positive traits	Negative traits
brave · honest · kind · curious · respectful · driven · adventurous	selfish · dishonest · stubborn · rude · mean · messy · forgetful
generous · patient · loyal · fair · cheerful · creative · hard-working	jealous · impatient · careless · bossy · sneaky · sly · fearful
determined · helpful · thoughtful · confident · compassionate	cowardly · greedy · cruel · lazy · thoughtless · insincere

Informational Text Structures

How authors organize nonfiction — and the clues that tell you which one you are reading

Every example below is about honey bees, so you can see one topic organized five different ways.

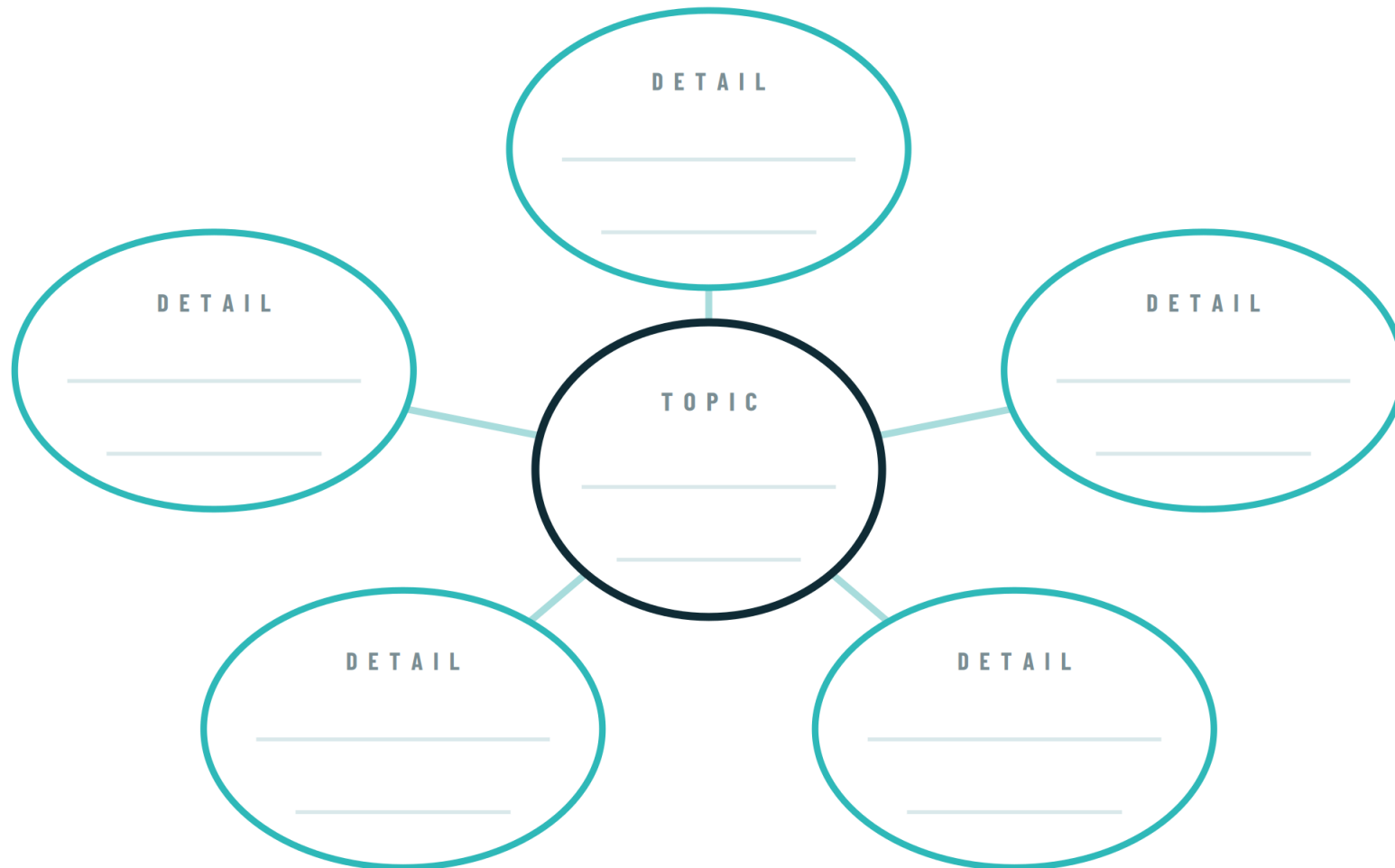
STRUCTURE	WHAT THE AUTHOR IS DOING	CLUE WORDS	VISUAL	EXAMPLE — ALL ABOUT HONEY BEES
Description	The author tells you what something is like by giving details, characteristics, and examples.	• for example • such as • characteristics • looks like • including		A honey bee has three body parts, six legs, and two pairs of wings. Fine hairs cover its body, and its back legs have stiff bristles that work like baskets for carrying pollen.
Chronological Order or Sequence	The author puts events or steps in the order they happen — a history told from beginning to end, or the steps in a process you could follow.	• first • next • then • after that • finally		First, a scout bee finds a patch of flowers. Next, she returns to the hive and dances in a pattern that shows the others which direction to fly. Then the workers follow her directions. Finally, they carry nectar home to become honey.
Compare + Contrast	The author shows how two or more things are alike and how they are different.	• both • alike • unlike • but • however • on the other hand		Both honey bees and bumble bees pollinate flowers. Honey bees live in large hives and store honey to eat all winter. Bumble bees, however, build small nests, and most of the colony does not survive the cold.
Cause + Effect	The author explains why something happened and what happened as a result. One event sets off another.	• because • so • since • as a result • this led to		Some farms sprayed strong pesticides across their fields. As a result, large numbers of honey bees died. Because fewer bees were left to pollinate, the crops in those fields produced less fruit.
Problem + Solution	The author names a problem and then explains one or more ways to fix it.	• problem • solution • one answer • to fix this • instead		Honey bees are losing the wildflowers they feed on. One solution is to plant native flowers in yards and along roadsides. Some towns now leave patches of clover unmowed so bees have food all summer long.

DESCRIPTION

Name _____ Date _____

FOCUS QUESTION What is/are _____?

Write your topic in the center oval. Add one detail, characteristic, or example in each outer oval.



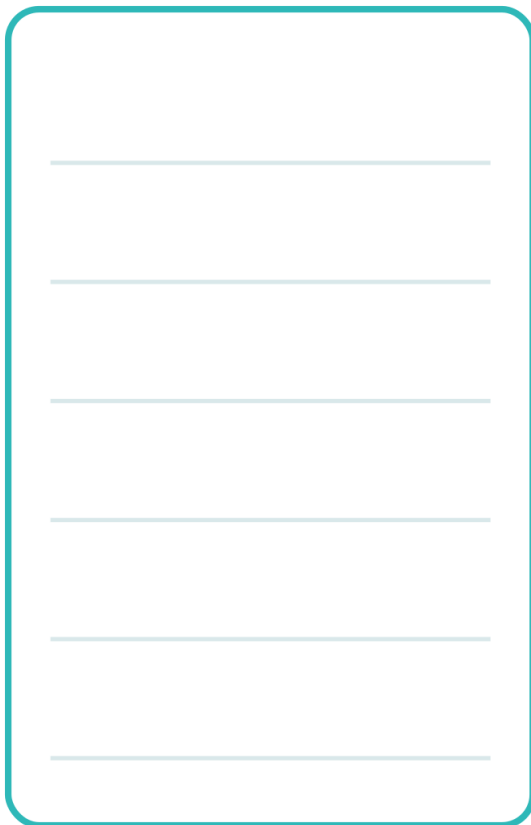
CHRONOLOGICAL ORDER OR SEQUENCE

Name _____ Date _____

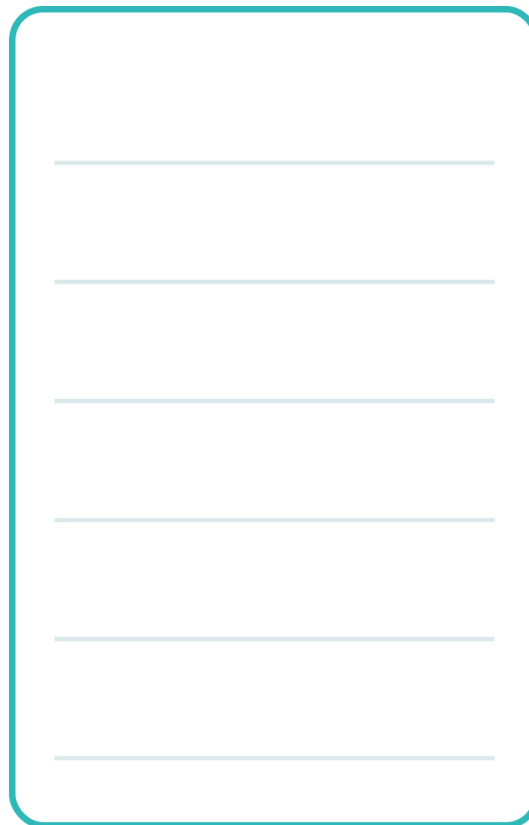
FOCUS QUESTION What happened first, next, and last?

Write the events or steps in the order the author gives them. Watch for the clue words first, next, then, after that, finally.

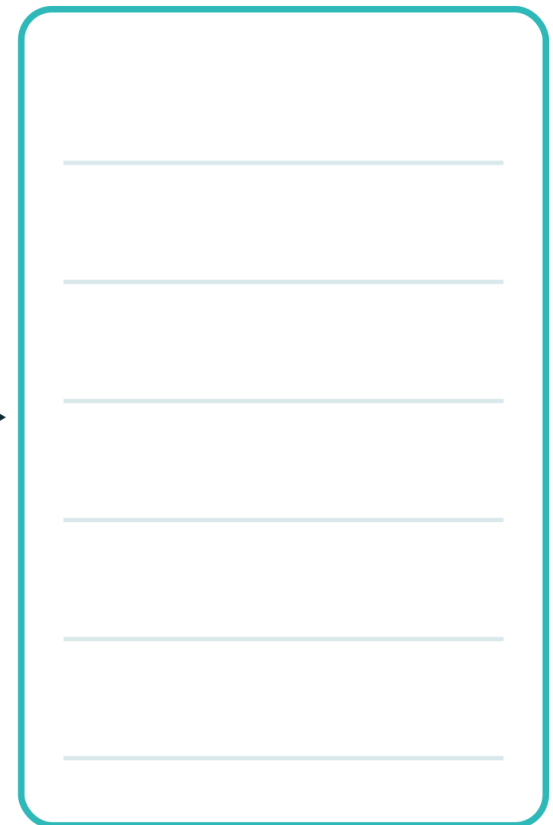
FIRST



NEXT



LAST



COMPARE + CONTRAST

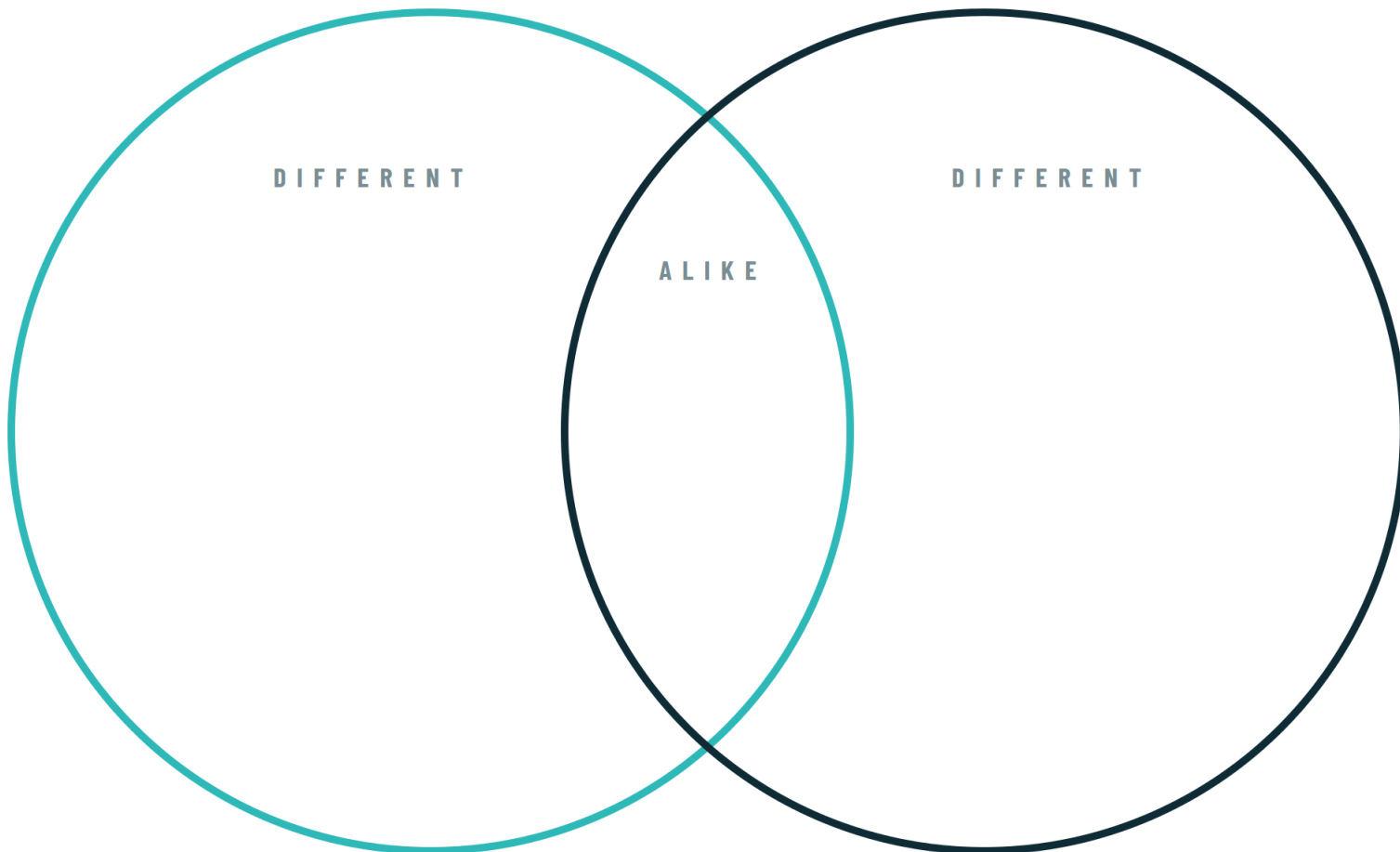
Name _____ Date _____

FOCUS QUESTION How are _____ and _____ similar and different?

Write what is true about only one item in each outer part. Write what is true about both in the middle.

ITEM _____

ITEM _____



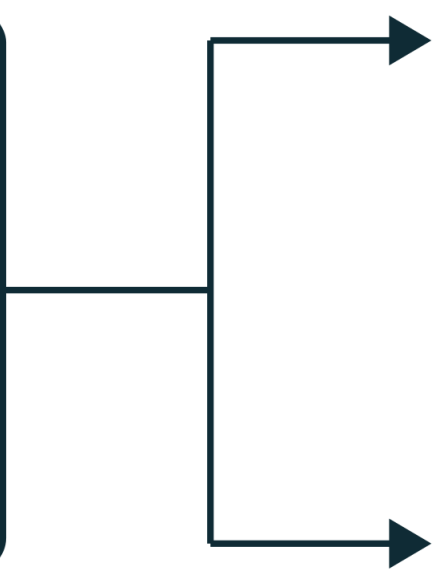
CAUSE + EFFECT

Name _____ Date _____

FOCUS QUESTION How are _____ and _____ related?

Write the cause in the dark box. Write what happened as a result in each effect box.

CAUSE



EFFECT

EFFECT

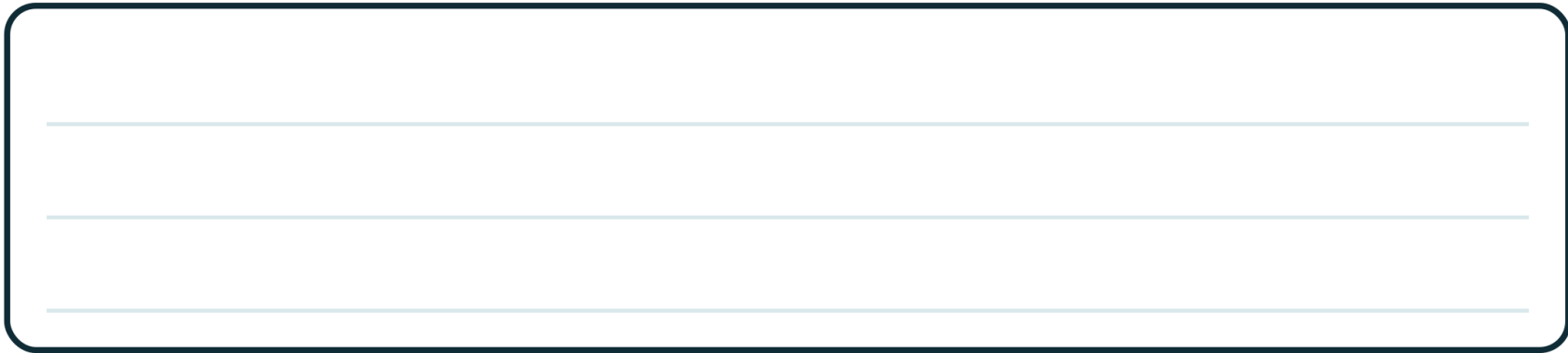
PROBLEM + SOLUTION

Name _____ Date _____

FOCUS QUESTION How was _____ solved?

Write the problem in the top box. Write one way the author says it can be fixed in the bottom box.

PROBLEM



SOLUTION

